



Own Your Club

A short, honest guide to running membership and club programs on rails you own — instead of renting them from a platform that takes a cut of every member.

PLECO CODEC · [PLECO.DEV](https://pleco.dev)

What this is

If you run a small food, drink, or hospitality business, you probably already have the most valuable thing there is: **regulars who come back**. A membership or club program turns that loyalty into steady, predictable revenue.

The common way to run one is to rent a platform — and pay it around **10% of every member, every month, forever**. That fee buys real things if you ship nationally. But if your members pick up or show up in person, you're paying for machinery you could simply own.

This guide makes the honest case for owning it instead: what a platform's fee actually buys, why owned infrastructure is more like an appliance than a subscription, whether it's secure, what upkeep really involves, and how to hire anyone to maintain it. No hype — where a platform is worth it, this says so.

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Pleco CODEC

The economics of owning your TMclub instead of renting it.

Subscription platforms take ~10% of your club revenue every month. Here is what that fee actually buys — and why, for a local pickup club, most of it is money spent on a problem you don't have.

WHERE THE 10% GOES

Platforms like Table22 charge ~10% of top-line plus payment processing. That fee bundles three things:

- **Fulfillment logistics** — labels, packing guidance, carrier coordination, national shipping
- **Lifecycle marketing** — automated welcome / winback / retention emails
- **Member support** — the platform's team fields pauses, refunds, address changes

The value of that bundle depends entirely on one question: do your members pick up, or do you ship?

SHIP vs. PICKUP: WHAT THE FEE IS WORTH

IF YOU SHIP

the fee earns its keep — but the costs stack up

- Carrier: ~\$18–30 charged, ~\$46 true cost cross-country for 6 bottles (subsidized)
- Packaging: molded pulp shippers, per box
- Pick / pack labor, every shipment
- Compliance: licensed shipper required by law
- Adult-signature + fuel + seasonal surcharges
- Platform 10% on top of all of it

IF THEY PICK UP

the fee pays for problems you don't have

- Carrier cost: \$0
- Packaging: \$0
- Pick / pack labor: folded into a shift
- Compliance: none — sale is on-premises*
- No surcharges, no lost-package claims
- Member walks in — and buys a drink, a pastry, a bottle they weren't planning on

*Off-premises package sales still require the correct license class; confirm with your licensing agent. Pickup avoids interstate shipping compliance, not licensing itself.

THE CODEC MODEL: RETENTION BY RITUAL, NOT BY LOGISTICS

A platform retains members by mailing boxes and automating emails. A pickup club retains them by giving them a reason to walk back through the door: a monthly tasting night, a members-first pour, a class, an early crack at a limited release. The pickup IS the retention event — and every visit is a chance at a second sale the platform never sees. CODEC builds that club on the payment rails you already run (Square or Stripe). One-time build. You own the code, the member list, and the billing relationship — and the ~10% stays in your register.

A WORKED EXAMPLE — 60-MEMBER LOCAL PICKUP CLUB

	On a platform	On CODEC
Club revenue / yr	\$43,200	\$43,200
Platform fee (~10%)	– \$4,320	\$0
Card processing (~2.9%+30¢)	– \$1,467	– \$1,467
Shipping + packaging	n/a (pickup)	n/a (pickup)
Kept by the business	\$37,413	\$41,733

\$4,320 back in the register the first year — the build pays for itself, then keeps paying. Every year. Forever.

Illustrative: 60 members × \$60/mo blended. Processing applies on either path since platforms charge 10% plus processing. Real figures come from your dashboard.



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You own your freezer. You shouldTM own this too.

You'd never rent your walk-in cooler from a company that took a cut of every steak you sold. So why rent your membership program from a platform that takes a cut of every member? Own the appliance.

YOUR DIGITAL INFRASTRUCTURE IS AN APPLIANCE

A walk-in freezer, a flat-top, an espresso machine — you buy them once, you own them, and any technician can service them because they're built to a standard. Your website and your club software are no different. CODEC is the appliance: built once, installed on equipment you own, running on standard parts anyone can work on.

OWN THE APPLIANCE vs. RENT IT FOREVER

OWN IT (CODEC)

like buying the freezer

- Bought once. It's yours.
- Runs on your own Square or Stripe
- Standard parts — any developer can service it
- Money lands in your bank, no cut taken
- You hold the keys; nobody can shut it off
- Optional service plan when you want it

RENT IT (a platform)

like leasing it back every month

- A fee every month, forever
- Runs on their system, not yours
- Locked to their platform — one vendor
- ~10% of every member skimmed off top
- They can reprice, sunset, or shut it down
- Leave, and your members don't come with you

ONE HONEST DIFFERENCE: APPLIANCES NEED THE OCCASIONAL SERVICE CALL

A freezer runs for years, but it still needs a coil cleaned now and then. Software's the same: an occasional update, a part that shifts when Square changes something on their end. That's the ONE thing to know — and it's exactly what the optional care plan covers. You're never paying rent on your own appliance; you're paying for a service call when you'd rather not think about it. Skip it and do your own upkeep with the docs, or call any developer. Your choice.

WHAT YOU ACTUALLY OWN WHEN IT'S INSTALLED

- **The appliance:** Your site + club system, in a code repo with your name on it — hand it to any developer.
- **The outlet it plugs into:** Your own Square or Stripe account. The money never routes through us.
- **The customer list:** Your members, in your dashboard, exportable any time. Never held hostage.

You own the flat-top. Own the software that runs your business the same way.



Security & Ownership

Why you can feel good owning this

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The fair question every owner asks before trusting a custom build: **is it secure, and am I exposed?** The honest answer is that a CODEC build is exposed to **less** than a typical platform — not because of promises, but because of how it is built. The most valuable things to steal simply are not there to steal.

THE ATTACK SURFACE IS SMALL BY DESIGN

- **Your site never touches card data.** Payment happens on Square's or Stripe's own secure pages. Card numbers never pass through your site — so they can't leak from it. There's no PCI compliance burden on you.
- **There's no customer database to breach.** Your member list lives in your own Square/Stripe account, not in a separate database on your site. There is no honeypot of customer data sitting there to be stolen.
- **The site is static.** A modern static build has almost no live "moving parts" for an attacker to exploit at request time — no live database queries, no server software running your business logic in the open.

SUPPLY-CHAIN SAFETY (THE DEPENDENCY QUESTION)

The real modern worry is a malicious update slipping in through a software component. CODEC is built to minimize exactly this:

- **Few components.** A lean build pulls in far fewer third-party pieces than a plugin-heavy website — a smaller surface to attack.
- **Version-locked.** Every component is pinned to an exact, verified version. A malicious update can't sneak in on a silent upgrade — the lock would have to be changed in a reviewed, deliberate step.
- **Alerted and deliberate.** Automated scanning flags any component with a known vulnerability. Updates are reviewed and tested before they go live — nothing auto-installs into your site behind your back.
- **Isolated.** Your site is its own independent deployment. Whatever happens to another business's site never touches yours — unlike a shared platform, where one problem can affect everyone at once.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU, PLAINLY

Your site can't leak customer cards because it never handles them. **There's no customer database to breach** because your members live in your own Square account. **The site is a handful of known, version-locked parts** — not a sprawl of plugins that go stale and get exploited. **Updates are deliberate**, reviewed, and tested. And your site is **isolated** — nothing that happens elsewhere touches it.

The honest limit: no software is unhackable, and any claim otherwise should make you trust the seller less, not more. The real, defensible claim is this: a CODEC build gives an attacker **less to reach** — no cards, no customer database, few and locked components, deliberate updates, and isolation — than you are exposed to renting from a platform that holds everyone's data in one place. You can also see exactly what you're running, because the code is yours.

Pleco CODEC · pleco.dev · This describes how a CODEC build is maintained; it is not a security guarantee — no software is risk-free. See the honest framing within.



Maintaining Your Build

What upkeep actually looks like

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A common worry with a custom build is "what happens when it needs upkeep?" Here is the honest answer: **a CODEC site needs very little to keep running**, because the heavy lifting (hosting, billing, security-scaling) is handled by the same services large companies rely on. Here is exactly what upkeep looks like — whether you do it yourself or hire anyone to.

WHAT UPKEEP ACTUALLY IS

Your site is a modern static build with checkout handled by Square or Stripe. It does not "rot" the way an old plugin-heavy website does. Real maintenance is small and infrequent:

- **Dependency updates** — every 1–3 months, apply security patches to the site's software components. Automated tools flag exactly which ones; applying them is minutes of work, done deliberately and tested.
- **Content changes** — only when you want one: a new club tier, a price change, a new photo. On-demand, not scheduled.
- **That's the routine.** The site doesn't need babysitting. Hosting, SSL, and scaling are automatic. There is no server for you to patch and no software that silently expires.

THE EDGE CASES (RARE, AND PLANNED FOR)

What could happen	How often	What it takes
Square/Stripe changes their API	Rare — long warning windows	A one-time update to the connector. Small, scheduled work.
A software component needs a fix	Occasional	Update or roll back to the last known-good version. Your build is version-locked, so this is controlled, not chaotic.
Domain / SSL renewal	Automatic	Nothing — unless the card on file expires. That's yours to keep current.
A payment notification hiccups	Rare	The system retries automatically. Manual attention is the exception.

TWO WAYS TO HANDLE IT — BOTH REAL

Do it yourself (\$0/mo): you get written documentation. Content and tier changes you can do in minutes. Dependency updates are a periodic, well-documented task any developer can run — and you can call any

developer to do it, because it's a standard stack, not something exotic.

Care plan (\$100–200/mo): Pleco (or your chosen developer) handles updates, monitoring, and small changes so you never think about it. Cancel anytime; you keep everything. This is a service call, not rent — you already own the appliance.

The honest part: "low maintenance" is not "zero maintenance." Software needs the occasional update, like an appliance needs the occasional service. The difference from a rented platform is that **you decide when and who** — nothing changes on your site automatically, behind your back, and you are never locked to a single provider to do it.

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Hiring a Developer

For maintaining or extending your build

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You own your CODEC build outright — code, data, and accounts. That means you can hire **anyone** to maintain or extend it; you are never locked to one provider. Here is exactly what to look for, where to find them, and how to tell a good developer from a bad one.

YOU ARE NOT LOOKING FOR SOMEONE RARE

CODEC is built on the most common web stack there is. That's deliberate — it means if you ever need help, the talent pool is enormous, not a handful of specialists who can hold you hostage. The single phrase to use when looking:

"A React / Next.js developer comfortable with Stripe or Square." That describes a huge, standard pool of developers. You are hiring for a conventional skill set, not a rare one.

THE SKILLS TO SEARCH FOR

If a developer knows these, they can maintain or extend your build. You don't need one who knows all of them — the first two cover most needs:

Next.js / React TypeScript Astro Stripe or Square API webhooks Sanity (or headless CMS) Vercel

- **Next.js / React + TypeScript** — the site itself. The core skill; the largest talent pool.
- **Stripe or Square API + webhooks** — the billing piece. This is the one to actually ask about (see below), because it's where the money flows.
- **Astro, Sanity, Vercel** — site framework, content editing, and hosting. Standard, quick for anyone in this stack to pick up.

WHERE TO FIND THEM

- **Ask us first.** Whoever built your site can usually point you to someone who works in the same stack.
- **Local.** Web-development meetups, local tech community groups, and nearby coding-program alumni boards are full of developers in this exact stack.
- **Freelance platforms.** Established marketplaces work, but vet harder there — you don't have a local reputation to go on. Use the checklist below.

HOW TO VET A GOOD ONE

- **Ask to see 2–3 live sites they've shipped** — real ones you can visit, not mockups or screenshots.
- **Ask directly: "Have you worked with Stripe or Square webhooks?"** — a clear yes with an example means they understand the billing part, which is what matters most.
- **Start with one small paid task** — a content change or a dependency update — before a big engagement. A cheap way to test whether they're reliable and communicate well.
- **Confirm they'll work in YOUR accounts** — your Vercel, your Square, your GitHub — not host it under theirs. A good developer agrees to this immediately; it's normal.

GREEN FLAGS AND RED FLAGS

Good signs: shows real shipped work · comfortable with Stripe/Square · agrees to work in your accounts · happy to start with a small task · explains things plainly without making you feel dumb.

Walk away if: they won't show prior work · they insist on hosting it under their own account · they quote you a **monthly platform fee** to "manage" it (that's the exact rented-platform arrangement you left) · they can't answer the Stripe/Square question.

The bottom line: you own standard, conventional software — which is precisely why you're never trapped. Any competent web developer can maintain it, the talent pool is large, and this page is the whole job description. That's the point of owning it instead of renting it.

Owning your club

If a club fits your business, the path is simple and you own everything at the end of it:

- 1 **A short conversation.** What you sell, who your regulars are, and whether a club actually fits. If it doesn't, you'll hear that honestly.
- 2 **A one-time build** on your own Square or Stripe, your own site, your own accounts. Priced by scope — no per-member fee, no revenue share.
- 3 **You own it.** The code, the member list, the billing relationship — all yours. Maintain it yourself, keep an optional care plan, or hand it to any developer.

Own your club.

Let's talk about what it takes.

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